

recorder, and an integrated hands-free speaker. There are three modes of text input—T9 using the numeric keypad, an onscreen virtual keypad, and CIC's JotPro. The latter is a character recognition mode akin to Palm's Graffiti.

Connectivity and data transfer options include Bluetooth, Infrared, GPRS and HSCSD. You can surf the Web using the pre-installed WAP 2.0 HTML browser.

The multimedia capabilities of the device include support for the MP3, WAV, AMR, MIDI, RMF and iMelody formats with 24-note polyphony. All stored sound files in different formats can be set as ringtones. This means you can set your favourite MP3, or even an audio piece recorded using the sound recorder, as the tone for incoming calls or alarms.

The integrated digital camera captures images at 640 x 480, 320 x 240, or 160 x 120. You can choose three types of picture quality—high, medium and low. Capture modes are Auto, Indoor, Outdoor, and Night, and you can customise a lot of things. In video capture options, you can choose between three levels of video quality and two levels of audio quality. You can shoot videos for as long as you want, limited only by the amount of free memory. Still pictures are captured in the JPEG, and video in the MPEG-4 formats. As far as battery life is concerned, the lithium polymer battery packs in enough to last three days with normal use of phone, camera, multimedia and PDA features.

AnexTEK SP230 Pocket PC Phone

Price: Rs 30,000

The SP230 is a tad expensive at close to Rs 30,000. It is a full-fledged PDA running Microsoft Pocket PC 2003, and has an integrated GSM tri-band phone. But remember that at 109 x 68.5 x 21.6 mm and weighing 158 grams, the device is quite bulky. The detachable numeric flip keypad adds a few millimetres and grams on top of this. The thick, protruding antenna makes the device even more bulky, but also acts as a housing for the full-sized stylus.



Powered by an Intel PXA255 400 MHz processor, and well complemented by 64 MB of RAM, the SP230 boasts of a bright 3.5-inch transreflective TFT display that supports 65K colours with resolutions up to 240 x 320 pixels. However, advanced features such as Bluetooth and WiFi are missing.

The SP230 is decent as a phone, though it does have issues in areas with low network strength. The phone allows multiple conference calls and speed dial for 99 entries. As with most PDA phones, you need to copy your SIM contacts to the device to be able to use the contact management features properly. The SIM Manager does not allow messaging, so you can only send SMSes using the contacts stored in the device, or by entering the destination phone number directly. The numeric keypad is a flip that protects the screen by covering three-fourths of the area.

You get Pocket Word, Pocket Excel, Microsoft Reader, IE, Media Player, MSN Messenger, e-mail and standard PIM applications such as Calculator, Contacts, Calendar, Notepad, etc, pre-installed. The installed SIM Manager enables you to read and copy contacts from your SIM card, and also dial directly. There's also a backup utility called WiBackup. You can downclock the CPU to 200 MHz to save battery power. The 'Today' screen displays the number of unread messages, pending tasks and upcoming appointments. There are quite a few downloadable plugins for the Today screen that enhance functionality and make use of the phone simple. For example, a plugin called TodayPhone (www.funnysnake.com) displays missed and dialled calls on the Today screen, and even lets you call directly.

Synchronising the SP230 with a PC is simple using the bundled USB cradle and Microsoft ActiveSync software. Text can be input using the onscreen virtual keyboard, letter recognition and full-fledged handwriting recognition. The latter is fairly accurate once you get used to it, and should be quite convenient for SMS junkies. 

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